

Banned books are books or other printed works such as essays or plays which have been prohibited by law, or to which free access has been restricted by other means. The practice of banning books is a form of censorship, from political, legal, religious, moral, or commercial motives. This article lists notable banned books and works, giving a brief context for the reason that each book was prohibited. Banned books include fictional works such as novels, poems and plays and non-fiction works such as biographies and dictionaries.

The usual reasons for banning books are pornography and obscenity, including child porn, anti-government or revolutionary provocation, propagating extremist philosophy such as Nazism, agitation of hate, instructions on violence, homicide or preparing illegal weapons and/or munitions, and/or blasphemy, especially in Islamic countries. Many books have been banned because of multiple reasons.

Since there have been a large number of banned books, some publishers have sought out to publish these books. The best-known examples are the Parisian Obelisk Press, which published Henry Miller's sexually frank novel *Tropic of Cancer*, and Olympia Press, which published William S. Burroughs's *Naked Lunch*. Both of these, the work of father Jack Kahane and son Maurice Girodias, specialized in English-language books which were prohibited, at the time, in Great Britain and the United States. Ruedo ibérico, also located in Paris, specialized in books prohibited in Spain during the dictatorship of Francisco Franco. Russian literature prohibited during the Soviet period was published outside of Russia.

Many countries throughout the world have their own methods of restricting access to books, although the prohibitions vary strikingly from one country to another. The following list of countries includes historical states that no longer exist.

Albania

Argentina

Australia

Austria

Bangladesh

Belgium

Bosnia and Herzegovina

Brazil

Canada

Chile

China

Czechoslovakia

Egypt

El Salvador

Eritrea

France

Germany

Weimar Republic (1918–1933)

Nazi Germany (1933–1945)

East Germany (1949–1990)

West Germany (1949–1990) and Germany (1990–present)

In today's Germany, a book is considered banned if it has been confiscated by a court. The distribution of a confiscated book is prohibited, but private possession and reading is still legal (with the exception of child and youth pornographic material, where possession is already a criminal offense).

The official list of confiscated books was published by the Federal Department for Media Harmful to Young Persons (Bundeszentrale für Kinder- und Jugendmedienschutz) in the magazine "BzKJaktuell" until the beginning of 2022.

The list of confiscated books should not be confused with books on the "List of Media Harmful

to Young Persons" (colloquially known as the "Index"). Books indexed by the Federal Department for Media Harmful to Young Persons are subject to strict restrictions and may only be offered and sold to adults.

List of books confiscated for violating Criminal Code 86, 86a, 130 or 130a

This list collectively lists media that violate one of the following paragraphs:

Section 86: Dissemination of propaganda material of unconstitutional and terrorist organisations

Section 86a: Use of symbols of unconstitutional and terrorist organisations

Section 130: Incitement of masses

Section 130a: Instructions for committing criminal offences

List of books confiscated for violating Criminal Code 131

This list contains media that violate the following paragraph:

Section 131: Depictions of violence

Greece

Guatemala

India

Indonesia

Iran

Ireland

Israel

The importation of books published in enemy countries is forbidden. These currently include

Iraq, Lebanon, and Syria.

Italy

Japan

Kenya

Kuwait

Lebanon

Liberia

Malaysia

Mauritius

Morocco

Myanmar

Nepal

Netherlands

New Zealand

Nigeria

Norway

Pakistan

Papal States

Papua New Guinea

Philippines

Poland

Portugal

Qatar

Roman Empire

Russia

Soviet Union

Saudi Arabia

Senegal

Singapore

South Africa

South Korea

Spain

Sri Lanka

Tanzania

Taiwan

Thailand

Uganda

Ukraine

United Arab Emirates

United Kingdom

United States

Uruguay

Uzbekistan

Vietnam

Yugoslavia

See also

Censorship by country

Criticism of Amazon

Areopagitica: A speech of Mr John Milton for the liberty of unlicensed printing to the
Parliament of England

Banned Books Museum

Book burning

Burning of books and burying of scholars

Internet censorship

Challenge (literature)

International Freedom of Expression Exchange

Index Librorum Prohibitorum

List of authors and works on the Index Librorum Prohibitorum

List of banned films

List of banned video games

List of book burning incidents

Television censorship

References

Further reading

Banned Books, 4 volumes, Facts on File Library of World Literature, 2006.

Literature Suppressed on Political Grounds ISBN 0-8160-6270-6

Literature Suppressed on Religious Grounds ISBN 0-8160-6269-2

Literature Suppressed on Sexual Grounds ISBN 0-8160-6272-2

Literature Suppressed on Social Grounds ISBN 0-8160-6271-4

Academic freedom in Indonesia, Human Rights Watch, 1998

Paying the price: freedom of expression in Turkey, Lois Whitman, Thomas Froncek, Helsinki Watch, 1989

Karolides, Nicholas J. (2006). Banned Books: Literature Suppressed on Political Grounds. New York, NY: Facts on File, Inc. ISBN 0-8160-6270-6.

Darnton, Robert (1996). The Forbidden Best-Sellers of Pre-Revolutionary France. New York, NY: W. W. Norton & Co. ISBN 0393314421.

External links

[Beacon For Freedom of Expression](#)

[The Literature Police: Apartheid Censorship and its Cultural Consequences](#)

[Top 100 Banned Classic Books](#)

[The Banned Books Museum - Censored Books from Across The World](#)

[New Zealand Office of Film & Literature Classification](#)

[Australia classification board](#)

[UK libraries "Banned books 2011" challenging censorship in literature](#)

[Banned Books That Shaped America](#)

[Banned Books and Prints in Europe and the United States, 17th–20th Centuries](#)

[Banned Books — An independent international catalogue of books banned by governments, schools, and libraries](#)